

Inside [More Sports](#):

[Motor Sports](#)

[Pro Basketball](#)

[Golf](#)

[Other Sports](#)

[Olympics](#)

[PG Store](#)

[Directory](#)

[Dining](#)

Hidden Valley develops hidden talent: biking

Saturday, June 19, 2010

By Larry Walsh

Hidden Valley wants to become as well known for bicycling opportunities as it is for quality golf and snow sports.

To accomplish that goal, the resort is offering a variety of stay-here, bike-there overnight packages that start at \$99 per person. Guests also can rent top-of-the-line bikes at the resort.

"[Guests] can experience the outdoors and beautiful scenery of the Great Allegheny Passage and the Laurel Highlands while enjoying quality time with family and friends," said resort spokesman **Robert Duppstadt**, a veteran mountain, road and trail cyclist.

He said the resort's shuttle service to five trailhead towns along the passage allows guests "to plan the perfect ride for their group's ability and fitness level." Guests have their choice of one-way or up-and-back rides from Meyersdale, Rockwood, Confluence, Ohiopyle and/or Connellsville.

It is 12 miles from Meyersdale to Rockwood, 19 miles from Rockwood to Confluence, 11 from Confluence to Ohiopyle and 17 from Ohiopyle to Connellsville.

The 59 mile one-way ride between Meyersdale and Connellsville includes five bridges, including the scenic Salisbury Viaduct and the Pinkerton High Bridge, and miles of tree-canopied segments of the trail.

Although the wide, crushed limestone trail is almost level, those who begin their rides in Meyersdale will find the pedaling a bit easier as the trail descends in elevation from 2,106 feet in Meyersdale to 1,826 feet in Rockwood, 1,353 in Confluence, 1,230 in Ohiopyle and 905 in Connellsville.

Duppstadt said the shuttle service picks up guests at the end of their ride and returns them to the resort "to refresh, recover, relax and enjoy an evening in the mountains."

The packages include lodging, continental breakfast, shuttle service, use of the outdoor pool and fitness center, which has an indoor pool and hot tub, paddle-boat rental, basketball, badminton, horseshoes and volleyball.

For more information, go to www.hiddenvalleyresort.com or call 1-814-443-8000.

Work and roll

The Pittsburgh Trails Advocacy Group (PTAG) will play host to a "Laurel Mountain Work and Roll Weekend" today and Saturday in support of the Laurel Mountain Volunteer Group's first Trail Care Day.

"This is a great opportunity for everyone who enjoys the beautiful trails at Laurel Mountain to kick something back, break a sweat and make the trails even better and more enjoyable," said **Frank "Jeff" Wuerthele**, the PTAG steward for Forbes State Forest.

Wuerthele, who works for Dirt Rag magazine, said the state Department of Conservation and Natural Resources will provide free camping on the mountain tonight at "Motorized Site No. 1."

Volunteers will meet at 9:30 a.m. today at the parking lot adjacent to the warming hut along Summit Road, just down from the entrance to Laurel Mountain Ski Area.

The work session is scheduled to wrap up at 2:30 when cold refreshments will be self-served.

PTAG, which has been instrumental in the construction and maintenance of mountain bike trails in city, county and state parks, will play host to a series of "brisk and casual-paced rides" beginning at 10 a.m. tomorrow that offer "multiple bail points."

For more information, go to www.ptagtrails.com

Passage history

"An Uncommon Passage: Traveling through History on the Great Allegheny Passage," an excellent book edited by **Edmund Fuller** with photographs by **Paul Wiegman**, will be discussed -- and autographed -- at 7 p.m. Tuesday at the REI store at Settlers Ridge in Robinson and at 7 p.m. Wednesday at the REI store on the South Side.

For more information, call 412-747-1180 or 412-488-9410.

Larry Walsh writes about recreational bicycling for the Post-Gazette.

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